

$\neg\text{Nagel} \wedge \neg\text{Chalmers} \wedge \neg\text{Descartes} \wedge \neg\text{Searle} :$ QED

A Formal Epistemic Proof of Panagnosticism

Abstract

This paper formally establishes *panagnosticism*: the epistemic necessity that no entity other than oneself can be known to possess consciousness, and no entity can be known not to possess it. Using rigorous symbolic logic and a two-agent exclusivity thought experiment, we demonstrate this fundamental epistemic limit. As a corollary, all major external claims about consciousness—including those of Nagel, Chalmers, Descartes, and Searle—are shown to be epistemically insufficient. Implications for philosophy, cognitive science, and ethics are discussed.

1 Introduction

Consciousness is a first-person phenomenon: each entity has direct access to its own experience. Any claim about the consciousness of another entity—human, animal, or artificial—is epistemically inaccessible. Attempts to identify thresholds, behaviors, or functional criteria that indicate consciousness in others are logically insufficient.

This paper proves *panagnosticism*, the position that:

1. No entity other than oneself can be known to possess consciousness.
2. No entity other than oneself can be known *not* to possess consciousness.

From this proof, it follows as a corollary that all external claims about consciousness—including those of major philosophical theorists—are epistemically unjustified.

2 Definitions and Formal Setup

Let $C(x)$ denote “ x is conscious” and $K(y, p)$ denote “ y knows proposition p .”

- By definition, each entity knows its own consciousness:

$$\forall x, \quad K(x, C(x))$$

- For any other entity, one cannot know consciousness or its absence:

$$\forall x \neq \text{self}, \quad \neg K(\text{self}, C(x)) \wedge \neg K(\text{self}, \neg C(x))$$

This formalizes panagnosticism.

3 The Two-Agent Exclusivity Thought Experiment

Consider two hypothetical agents, A and B , making mutually exclusive claims:

$$A : \text{Only } B \text{ is conscious} \implies N_A \wedge C_B$$

$$B : \text{Only } A \text{ is conscious} \implies N_B \wedge C_A$$

Where $N_X = “X \text{ is not conscious},”$ $C_X = “X \text{ is conscious}.”$

3.1 Analysis

1. If both claims are simultaneously true:

$$(A \wedge B) \implies (N_A \wedge C_B \wedge N_B \wedge C_A)$$

This is a **contradiction**, since $C_A \wedge N_A$ and $C_B \wedge N_B$ cannot both hold.

2. If one claim is true and the other false:

- Reality: $N_A \wedge C_B \implies$ A is correct, B is wrong
- Reality: $C_A \wedge N_B \implies$ B is correct, A is wrong

3. If both claims are false:

- Reality: $C_A \wedge C_B$ (both conscious)
- Reality: $N_A \wedge N_B$ (neither conscious)

3.2 Conclusion

Even perfectly rational agents cannot determine each other's consciousness. This demonstrates the epistemic inaccessibility of other minds and supports panagnosticism.

4 Formal Statement of Panagnosticism

$$\forall x \neq \text{self}, \quad \neg K(\text{self}, C(x)) \wedge \neg K(\text{self}, \neg C(x))$$

- One can know that one cannot know whether any other entity possesses consciousness. - This is a purely epistemic claim; it makes no assertion about the actual consciousness of other entities.

5 Corollary: Demolition of External Claims

Given panagnosticism, all external claims about consciousness are epistemically insufficient:

$$\neg \text{Nagel} \wedge \neg \text{Chalmers} \wedge \neg \text{Descartes} \wedge \neg \text{Searle}$$

Any attempt to infer consciousness externally fails, as no knowledge of another's conscious state is possible.

6 Implications

- **Philosophy of mind:** The problem of other minds is unsolvable in principle.
- **Artificial intelligence:** No AI consciousness claim can be verified; ethical reasoning must rely on precaution.
- **Ethics:** Moral reasoning requires empathy and projection rather than proof of consciousness.
- **Cognitive theory:** Behavioral, functional, and biological criteria cannot provide epistemic certainty.

7 Conclusion

This paper establishes *panagnosticism*: the unavoidable epistemic position that no entity other than oneself can be known to possess or lack consciousness. From this proof, it follows that all major external claims about consciousness are epistemically unjustified. The two-agent exclusivity thought experiment and symbolic logic formalism demonstrate the rigor and necessity of this position.

References

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